WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

GEORGIA

Eurasia

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Tbilisi	Capital and commercial centre; home to the banking sector, which drew the largest share of 2025 FDI, and to the 17-hectare Tbilisi Free Zone	Financial services, ICT, real estate, trade
Poti (Black Sea coast)	Georgia's main container gateway, operated by APM Terminals and handling around 80% of national container traffic; site of the first free industrial zone in the Caucasus, established in 2008	Port logistics, transit trade, export manufacturing
Anaklia Deep Sea Port	State-owned deep-water port under a landlord model, with dredging under way since August 2026 and phase one ($1.1 billion, 600,000 containers a year) targeted for 2029, alongside a planned free industrial zone	Terminal operation, logistics, industrial zone development
Batumi / Adjara	Black Sea port city with an oil terminal serving Kazakh and Azerbaijani transit, and Georgia's leading coastal tourism destination in an economy where inbound travel income equalled 12.3% of GDP in 2025	Tourism and hospitality, real estate, oil and cargo transit
Kutaisi	Western regional centre hosting free industrial zones, including one developed by China's Hualing Group in 2015	Manufacturing, logistics, light industry
Akhalkalaki / Baku–Tbilisi–Kars railway	826 km rail link connecting Azerbaijan, Georgia and Türkiye, with a gauge-change facility at Akhalkalaki; Baku–Tbilisi passenger service resumed in May 2026	Rail freight, Middle Corridor transit, logistics
Kakheti (east)	Agricultural heartland where the World Bank-backed TC-GATE programme is building four-lane road sections and cutting Telavi–Poti travel time by about 43 minutes	Wine, agro-processing, tourism

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Enterprise Georgia's Investment Division (Invest in Georgia), under the Ministry of Economy and Sustainable Development, acts as a one-stop shop for foreign investors

- Law on Promotion and Guarantee of Investment Activity, protecting foreign investors for 10 years against later legislation that changes the conditions of their investment, alongside ICSID membership (since 1992), the New York Convention and a US–Georgia Bilateral Investment Treaty
- Four free zones (Poti, two in Kutaisi and the Tbilisi Free Zone) offering profit-tax exemption on permitted activities, duty- and VAT-free import of foreign goods and property-tax exemption
- Distributed-profit tax model since 2017: 15% corporate tax applies only when profits are distributed, while International Company status offers a 5% rate for qualifying IT, software and certain shipping services
- Free-floating lari with no restrictions on current international payments (IMF Article VIII); investors may convert and repatriate after-tax income freely
- Development Fund of Georgia (formerly the Partnership Fund) offering co-investment through equity and subordinated loans in early-stage projects
- Anaklia Deep Sea Port landlord model, under which international terminal operators are expected to invest an estimated $350–400 million in terminal infrastructure

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Georgia in October 2026 is one of the fastest-growing economies in the wider region. GDP grew 7.5% in 2025 and 7.6% in January–August 2026, led by manufacturing, information and communication, finance and transport, and the World Bank projects 7.0% growth for 2026. Foreign direct investment rose 19.3% to $1.9 billion in 2025, with the United Kingdom the largest source ($426.6 million), followed by Azerbaijan and Türkiye. Macroeconomic buffers have strengthened markedly: gross international reserves reached a record $8.14 billion in August 2026, up 56.4% year-on-year and 128.2% of the IMF adequacy metric, while public debt stood at a moderate 34.3% of GDP in 2025. The National Bank of Georgia is holding its policy rate at 8.25% to bring inflation (5.6% in September, driven mainly by Middle East energy prices) back to its 3% target, and multilateral lenders remain active, including the $752 million TC-GATE transport programme approved in June 2026 to strengthen Georgia's Middle Corridor role.

Georgia's main structural consideration is its relationship with the European Union. Its accession process has been de facto halted since the government announced in November 2024 that it would not open talks before the end of 2028; the EU suspended visa-free travel for holders of Georgian diplomatic and official passports in March 2026 and may consider wider measures, with a decision expected around January 2027. The economy has nonetheless continued to grow strongly, and the core commercial architecture remains in place: the EU Deep and Comprehensive Free Trade Area (in force since 2014), free trade agreements with China, EFTA, Türkiye and others, and continued financing from the World Bank, EBRD, ADB and AIIB. For investors, this means focusing on trade, transit and services opportunities that do not depend on the pace of accession, while building in strong governance and compliance processes and positioning for the upside should EU relations improve.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
EU accession process de facto halted	EU Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos has called Georgia a candidate 'only on paper'; official-passport visa-free travel is suspended and wider visa measures are under review, with a decision expected around January 2027	The DCFTA remains in force and EU–Georgia trade reached about €5.2 billion in 2025; structure EU-facing business under it and treat any improvement in relations as upside
Targeted US and UK sanctions on individuals	There are no country-wide sanctions, but the US designated Bidzina Ivanishvili and several senior officials in December 2024, the UK designated two Georgian businessmen in September 2025, and further US legislation (the MEGOBARI Act) has been proposed	Retain sanctions counsel and screen all counterparties and beneficial owners against US, UK and EU lists before contracting
Russian occupation of Abkhazia and South Ossetia	Russia occupies nearly 20% of Georgia's territory; economic activity there without Georgian permits is illegal, and mineral exploration, money transfers and international transit are banned	Confine operations to government-controlled territory, where the investment, port and transit opportunities are concentrated

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Russia-linked trade and re-export flows	Russia is a top-three export market and import source, and passenger cars make up about a quarter of exports, which calls for care with sanctions and export-control rules	Apply end-use and end-user checks on transit and re-export business; Middle Corridor growth offers a diversified alternative
Judicial predictability and rule of law	The US Investment Climate Statement notes concerns over judicial independence and slow resolution of commercial cases, and the IMF recommends anti-corruption and judicial reforms	Use international arbitration (ICSID, New York Convention, GIAC), the 10-year statutory stability guarantee and the Business Ombudsman
Above-target inflation and dollarisation	Inflation was 5.6% in September 2026 against a 3% target, and deposit dollarisation is about 47%, although record reserves of $8.14 billion support the lari	Hedge local-currency exposure; the central bank expects to ease policy once the energy-price shock fades
Labour market and new work-permit rules	Unemployment remains high at 13.8% (Q2 2026), and since March 2026 most foreign employees need an employer-specific right to work, with quotas added in July 2026	Plan expatriate staffing early and invest in local skills, drawing on a large available workforce

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Georgia's risk profile combines strong macroeconomic performance with a political and diplomatic environment that investors should follow closely. Growth of 7.5% in 2025 and 7.6% in the first eight months of 2026, record reserves of $8.14 billion, moderate public debt and a sound banking sector give the economy real resilience, and the World Bank, EBRD, ADB and AIIB continue to commit significant financing. The main considerations are the de facto halt in EU accession, the possibility of wider EU visa measures in early 2027, and targeted US and UK sanctions on Georgian individuals, including the founder of the governing party. These are not country-wide sanctions, and lawful investment in Georgia remains broadly open, but counterparty and beneficial-ownership screening should be standard, supported by sanctions counsel. Russia's occupation of Abkhazia and South Ossetia means investment should be limited to government-controlled territory, and trade businesses should apply export-control checks to re-export flows. With these safeguards in place, investors can benefit from Georgia's growth, low-tax regime and expanding transit role, while positioning for further upside if relations with the EU improve.

MARKET ACCESS

Georgia has been a WTO member since June 2000 and offers one of the broadest free trade networks in the region: a Deep and Comprehensive Free Trade Area with the EU (provisionally applied since September 2014, with the Association Agreement in force since 2016), a free trade agreement with China (in force since January 2018), and agreements with EFTA, Türkiye, CIS countries, Hong Kong and the United Arab Emirates. EU–Georgia trade reached about €5.2 billion in 2025. In January–August 2026, Georgia's largest export markets were Kyrgyzstan ($577.6 million), China ($543.7 million) and Russia ($500.7 million), with passenger cars, petroleum products and precious-metal ores the leading exports. Georgia is a key link on the Trans-Caspian International Transport Route (Middle Corridor), connecting Central Asia and Azerbaijan with Black Sea ports at Poti and Batumi, the Baku–Tbilisi–Kars railway to Türkiye and, from 2029, the Anaklia deep-water port.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Irakli Kobakhidze)	Sets economic policy and leads flagship projects, including the $7 billion strategic transport investment plan to 2032	Primary reference point for Georgia's strategic and policy direction
Enterprise Georgia (Investment Division / Invest in Georgia)	National investment promotion body and one-stop shop for foreign investors	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive guidance
Ministry of Economy and Sustainable Development	Oversees investment policy, free zones and the state-owned Anaklia Deep Sea	Key counterpart for port, logistics and

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	Port	free-zone investment
National Bank of Georgia	Monetary authority managing the floating lari, record reserves and banking supervision	Relevant for currency, banking and financial-services matters
Ministry of Finance	Manages public finances and borrowing from international financial institutions, including TC-GATE co-financing	Relevant for DFI-backed infrastructure and public-private partnerships
JSC Georgian Railway	State rail operator at the centre of Middle Corridor transit, receiving new electric locomotives under TC-GATE	Key partner for rail freight and logistics investment
Development Fund of Georgia	State investment fund co-investing in early-stage projects through equity and subordinated loans	Potential co-investor for energy, infrastructure and industrial projects
Business Ombudsman of Georgia	Independent office addressing business complaints about state bodies	Useful channel for resolving administrative issues

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The American Chamber of Commerce in Georgia (AmCham Georgia) is the leading international business association, with members including Bank of Georgia, TBC Group and PwC, while the British Georgian Chamber of Commerce, whose founder members include BP Georgia, Bank of Georgia and EY, supports UK–Georgia business links from London and Tbilisi, and the Georgian Chamber of Commerce and Industry is the main domestic business counterpart. Development finance institutions are deeply engaged: the EBRD has invested almost €6 billion across 322 projects since 1992, the World Bank Group's active portfolio totals $1.3 billion, the ADB and AIIB are co-financing the TC-GATE transport programme, and the US Development Finance Corporation and its predecessor have committed more than $780 million in Georgia since 1993. These institutions are valuable sources of co-financing, political-risk cover and practical market intelligence.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Georgia suits investors seeking a fast-growing, low-tax and open economy on a key Eurasian trade route: port, logistics and rail operators drawn by Anaklia terminal concessions, Poti and the Middle Corridor; infrastructure investors co-financing alongside the World Bank, EBRD, ADB and AIIB; financial-services investors in a sector that attracted a third of 2025 FDI; IT and software companies using International Company status; tourism and hospitality investors in an economy where inbound travel income is over 12% of GDP; and export-oriented manufacturers using the free industrial zones and wide free trade network. UK investors, already Georgia's largest source of FDI, are well placed. All investors should apply robust sanctions screening and governance standards and monitor developments in EU–Georgia relations.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage Enterprise Georgia and confirm incentive terms
Open dialogue with the Investment Division to confirm free-zone, International Company and investment-guarantee arrangements for the planned project.

STEP 2: Commission sanctions and counterparty due diligence
Screen partners and beneficial owners against US, UK and EU lists and apply export-control checks to any transit or re-export business, with support from experienced sanctions counsel.

STEP 3: Assess Anaklia and Middle Corridor logistics opportunities
Follow the Anaklia terminal-operator process, Poti port services and Georgian Railway modernisation to identify concessions and logistics partnerships ahead of the 2029 port target.

STEP 4: Co-invest alongside development finance institutions
Engage the EBRD, World Bank Group, ADB and the Development Fund of Georgia on co-financing and political-risk cover for infrastructure, energy and private-sector projects.

STEP 5: Structure contracts for legal certainty and monitor EU relations
Use international arbitration clauses and the statutory stability guarantee, and track EU visa and accession decisions expected from early 2027 as part of routine planning.